Issue1 October2002

THEGATE

Where reality meets virtuality



NEWS & VIEWS

All the latest news about
Project Entropia and MindArk

CALYPSO CHRONICLES

The diary of Ero Hartstenner

FEATURES

Creative writing from Calypsians

THEGATE

Issue 1, October 2002

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Welcome

to the inaugural issue of *The Gate*, the official magazine documenting the ever-evolving virtual world of Project Entropia and the real world surrounding it. This fanzine will be the gateway between virtuality and reality…hence the name.

The Gate is the evolution of MindArk's former 'Global News monthly newsletter', which was a short summary of development news, testing phase updates and information on the official website. That was then. This is now.

We here at *The Gate* want to set ourselves apart from the competition. This won't be an ordinary gaming fanzine. This magazine will have it all. If you still want the real life news on the development of Project Entropia, we've got it. If it's a profile or an interview you want, we've got it. If it's an editorial you want, we've got it. If it's a piece written by a fellow PE participant you want, we've got it. If it's cool screenshots you want, we've got it. If it's reviews you want, we've got it. Or maybe you just need a laugh; we've got that too (at least we will try our best to be funny). Our top priorities are to inform and entertain you, the user, and keep you coming back for more. We plan to make *The Gate* your favourite gaming mag and your soul source for info about PE (other than our website, of course)!

Step inside *The Gate*, take a look around and then tell us what you think. Do you like or dislike what we've done? Or maybe you want to contribute; whether it is an opinion piece, an item review or a tale about your time in Calypso, we want to hear from you. Send us your comments and other writing to fanzine@project-entropia.com.

Our editorial department is already hard at work on the next issue, which will be a more in-depth look inside the virtual world of Project Entropia. Stay tuned to the official website for release date details.



Cheers,
Stephanie Haines
Editor

Message from MindArk

Well, a lot has happened since we entered the Commercial Open Trial in May. This phase was introduced in order to test the different systems in Project Entropia with real users from around the world. With over 30 countries represented during this Phase we are confident in claiming global feedback to Project Entropia.

The Trial Phase has been invaluable to us for illustrating areas that needed more attention, but also for revealing our strengths. A healthy communication with our testing community has meant that we have been able to refine Project Entropia into the most modern and complete experience in online entertainment.

As with all projects, we faced many challenges along the way, but a sound mix of attentiveness and perseverance ensured that each challenge was met and resolved by the professional team working at MindArk.

The number of staff working at MindArk has also grown during this period, with new departments being initiated to deal with customer support and video production to name just a few. A new web site was created to reflect our growth and progress - a progress on all fronts.

A restructuring of the communications system, the introduction of a fabulous array of emotes for each character, a brand new vegetation motor as well as new creatures, treasures and outposts are carrying Project Entropia forward on a wave of enthusiasm to where we all want to be – the planet Calypso!



Infobooth 4.0

Makeover Madness

Notice anything different about our official website? Actually, notice anything the same? Infobooth 3.0 has been completely rebuilt and redesigned into version 4.0. The new and improved site is now more user-friendly and geared toward the average computer user, rather than a hard-core gamer. There have been several significant changes made to not only the look of the site, but its functionality.

Re-registration
This requires all users, new and old, to provide pertinent information so they will once again be registered on the site. No prior personal details have been stored onto the new design, which was the simplest way to merge version 3.0 and 4.0.

Forum/Community Integrated
The old community and old forum are all but a memory; they have both been integrated into the community section. This will be closed to non-registered users and will be easier to navigate. It is a perfect way to keep in close contact with friends and fellow society members about the latest happenings in PE.

Policies and Rules
Infobooth 4.0 will be a much more regulated environment. MindArk has written several new rules and policies that one must abide by when visiting the site. This is because we want the site to evolve and be an enjoyable place to visit for as many users as possible. MindArk may be forced to take action against those who disobey the set guidelines. All the policies will be laid out clearly on the site for you to read. Remember to read through all the small, but important boxes throughout the site.

Here are two other additions to the site we thought you may find interesting: The new 'Settings' option allows users to pick the font and color scheme they like to explore Infobooth 4.0 in, rather than having the one we chose. So if purple, black and grey aren't your colors, click away on the icon 'Settings'. Our webmaster also added the worldwide timezones to the front page which should alleviate much confusion about posting times on messages.

Check out the newly made over site at www.project-entropia.com to see what all the fuss is about. If you have any questions about Infobooth 4.0, email webmaster@project-entropia.com.

BEHIND THE SCENES

The following is a piece written by Cidium, a Canadian marketing student and PE enthusiast who spent a month with us this past summer interning in the PR department.

I've always wondered what it would be like to work for a game design company. What would the atmosphere be like? Would everyone work in one big room with a bunch of computers all networked together, or would they have their own office? Are they always in front of their computer, or do they go out for a few drinks like regular human beings? Fortunately, I've had the opportunity to have these, and many more questions answered during my stay in Sweden.

The first thing to impress me was the entrance at the MindArk office. In order to get into the building, you first must enter a security code. After that, you're still required to use a key to open the office doors. The office itself was quite larger than I had expected. When I first became interested in Project Entropia, there were very few employees, fifteen at most. Now that I was at the MindArk office, I had noticed first hand the growth that had taken place. I'm sure I saw at least 40 employees.

There were a few offices, but the majority of the office space was one large room. It was almost like something you would see at a LAN party, or game tournament. Monitors and cords were the only things I noticed walking past this area. I noticed that everyone was working with such enthusiasm, no one even saw me walking by the first couple days. I was really interested in seeing the server station that was powering the game world. One of the employee's was kind enough to show me, and it was larger than I had thought it would be. This server station was locked up most of the time behind a door that required a keycard for access. I think that was the only time I saw it. It took about a week or so before I was finally moved into the area I was to be working in. Wow, was I ever happy to get in there. One would think that attractive young women wouldn't be caught dead working for a game design company. This is definitely not the case in Sweden. Of all the cute ladies working at MindArk, I had two sitting right beside me in the Marketing area. That sure made it easier to wake up in the morning. For the most part, the people in my area were responsible for public relations, the fanzine, and attracting people to the community.

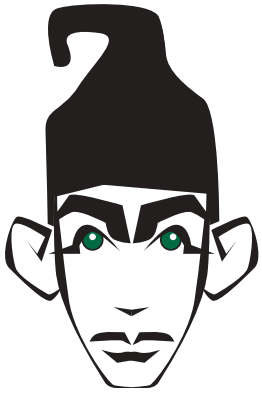
MindArk also did a great job dividing the office space into various areas. It seemed we all had our own location and area to work in. The programmers were all together at one end, and the customer service representatives were in another. It was great, and what was even better was the equipment we used. MindArk must have cut a deal with Sony or something, because most of us were using flat-screen Trinitron monitors (including me *grin*). One of the things I enjoyed the most was our meetings, held regularly of course. This gave everyone the opportunity to share their views and ideas openly, and every idea was considered. In the end, the final say was always up to the head honcho.

Everything seemed to be pretty routine after the first three weeks. As with any project, problems arose and solutions were found. We went out as groups to a few bars on occasion (wow alcohol is expensive in Sweden), and even took in some beach volleyball. The MindArk crew was quite easygoing, and very friendly. One of the employees even let me share his apartment for the duration of my stay.

It was a great experience, one that I will never forget. I think MindArk has a great vision. I hope they achieve their goal.

meet mindark

Ever wonder what the people behind the scenes at MindArk are REALLY like? Maybe you hear from some of them through posts on forum threads or replies to your emails, but you normally don't get much more.... Here's your chance. Meet Julien Nebbout.



Q: How old are you?
A: I just turned 22.

Q: A young MindArk talent. Where are you from…referring to your surname?
A: I was born in France, which is where my mother met my father. My father and his side of the family are originally from Algeria, but fled to France during the War of Independence around 1960. My middle name would appear more normal to Nordic people, being "David" from King David in the Bible.

Q: What do you do here at MindArk?
A: I'm working in the web department as a web/developer programmer.

Q: Can you explain exactly what that is?
A: I create and develop functionality for websites such as discussion forums, and communities, mainly for the Project Entropia site. Thommie (the Web manager) and I split the work, but because I have a programmer background, there are certain parts that I'm more suitable to do. Thommie is more focused on layout so I'm relieved from much of the work concerning site appearance.

cont...

Q: How long have you worked here?
A: I started a trial employment for six months in the middle of January this year. When it expired, I got regular employment and here I am.

Q: What's the best part of your job?
A: The best part is to do what I love, which is programming. Also, I couldn't really wish for a better partner than Thommie.

Q: What's the worst part of your job?
A: I suppose it is when a project grows too fast and loses focus and organisation. It happens every now and then that communication breaks down and people get confused over who said what. That tends to render a lot of unnecessary work.

Q: What do you think is the most important thing when you build a virtual world?
A: Mmmm...Being a mere mortal, I haven't done much "universe planning" in my days, but I would say that the user community is the vital part. The universe can't exist without its population, and if the population is stimulated, the universe grows and develops on its own.

Q: What do you think makes Project Entropia unique?
A: What doesn't make it unique? The vision is greater than anything I have ever encountered. The idea of truly creating a virtual world, not just a gaming platform, is extraordinary. To transfer daily life activities into a virtual world where you erase the boundaries of geography, sex and age is truly amazing.

Q: What is your favourite feature in Project Entropia?
A: I'm still waiting for MindForce to be implemented, as that is what has drawn my attention the most. I have a couple of ideas that I hope to slip in once they start adding MindForce abilities to Project Entropia.

Q: What's your most favorite thing to do other than come to MindArk everyday?!
A: The most frequent is having philosophical/political discussions with my girlfriend, visiting techno clubs to dance all night, playing around with UNIX systems and doing a lot of work for non-profit organisations.

PVP
Vent or Virus?

Frank Campbell

Sergey has sat hunched behind the ventilation shaft on the roof of the old abandoned bakery for almost ten minutes. It's a damp night in this old deserted part of town – the shabby streetlights guiding each rain droplet to their respective puddles. Through the telescopic sight mounted to his rifle, Sergey keeps his attention perfectly tuned to the far end of the street, where he expects his target at any moment.

Shapes alter as Gary steps from the shadows, right foot in front of left - in front of right, as he unwittingly assumes his evolutionary peak between Sergey's cross wires. Slowly, the hunter draws in a deep breath that touches Gary's consciousness just as the trigger is being squeezed. Gary swings around, realisation in his eyes and crumbles onto the wet street.

All this might sound like an international incident if it wasn't for the fact that Sergey and Gary are in fact eleven year olds, sitting in front of their computer terminals over three thousand miles from each other. Among the many benefits the Internet has afforded us – it has given us the opportunity to interact with others around the world in a manner that just didn't exist before.

Players of massive online role-playing games are used to battling each other in one fantastic arena after another with weapons of dizzying levels of destruction in a manner known as PvP – player versus player.

In the debate that exists around these products now, it is suggested that exposure and interaction with these games in fact desensitises children to violence. Without going too far into the numerous facts and opinions regarding this, there is one thought provoking question that can be asked: Is the violence perpetuated rewarded or punished?

Like most innovations in human culture however, it is our usage and intention that defines its effect. A lot of games do in fact nurture a sensitivity to teamwork, social contact, not to mention benefits to eye-hand coordination and reflex times. Problem solving and logic are also key elements of many games.

It could be said that the negative effects of violent entertainment only affect a small proportion of the community and that this group may have been unstable anyway, but a distinguishing quality of our societies is that we care for the weaker elements. Many people seem to use the freedom of speech and action in our societies as an excuse for their own apathy and moral emptiness.

With worldwide video game sales reaching 20 billion per year we may assume that this form of entertainment is here to stay.

Project Entropia at this stage does not include a PvP function and our development team is busy formulating an approach to this subject, which will be both entertaining and responsible to our customers.

Send any comments you have to: fanzine@project-entropia.com



Being a Woman in a Virtual World

Helen Praetorius

When we hear the term 'virtual world' it means well, an escape from the real world. Since the beginning of online gaming, men have seemed to crave this adventure more than women. Today however, more women are jumping on the bandwagon; research shows that about half of all online gamers are female.

I wanted to find out what attracts women to online games, so I contacted Anna Maria Szczepanska, who wrote a detailed paper for Gothenburg University on users' experiences of virtual worlds. After 300 hours over a 7 month period inside a virtual world, Anna Maria herself went from being a person who had never been involved with online entertainment to what we would call a hardcore gamer.

One of the most enticing things for women is the fact that they can be someone else entirely. "First of all, it's amazing that you are able to live in two realities. People are pulled away from their real life perception when they act in a virtual world," says Anna Maria. "But that is something that the users perhaps would comment on as being a way of expanding themselves in their social reality."

As we all know, the social aspects of life are really important, especially from a woman's point of view. One of the first steps in an online game is creating an avatar or character. The great thing about virtual worlds is that you can create a look as crazy, creepy or cute as you like. Women like to have the freedom to choose. According to Anna Maria, the look of the avatar only plays a slight role in defining who you are and who your acquaintances will be in game. Prejudice is almost non-existent with respect to appearance. In real life, one's "look" is judged much more harshly, and people will determine whether or not to approach you, and the way to approach you, based on that first impression. In a virtual universe, those traits are often hidden and thus a more relaxed environment is created, where one is judged on one's thoughts and opinions rather than on one's looks.

This is the draw for women, the fact that a person's personality defines who they are. They are able to express themselves through writing. "It is my experience that women are excellent in developing their ability to present themselves and get attention by being funny, interesting, witty, exciting or smart," expresses Anna Maria. Virtual worlds give people the chance to interact with all types of individuals. Anna Maria interviewed one woman who met some of her online acquaintances in real life and said they weren't people she would normally associate with, but was thankful she took the opportunity.

Equality is another appealing quality in virtual worlds. Anna Maria's research shows that women enjoy online games because they are put on the same level as men in all areas. They don't have to fight for equal opportunities, as they do in the real world. Women can even put their professions to use in game. For example, Anna Maria got to know a female character who is a psychiatrist in real life. People came to her for advice on certain issues in game and some actually ended up booking appointments with her in real life afterwards.

Virtual worlds seem to provide endless opportunities for men and women alike, which is why more and more are getting hooked. The online gaming industry is growing at an unprecedented rate. DFC Intelligence estimates 114 million people worldwide will be playing online games by 2006. I wonder how many of those will be women and how many will be Project Entropia participants...

The Diary of Ero Hartstenner Part I

Frank Campbell



My name is Ero Hartstenner and my story is unknown to you. I was born in Albor Tholus on the cold, red rock they call Mars. The only child to some of the earliest Martian colonists, I grew up around a small mining installation my father established on the outskirts of a trading post called Klintanuwan. My parents worked hard, selling the ore and minerals they mined from the red planet to the local depot – we were comfortable. When I look back I think I had a happy childhood. I remember birthdays and playing with other 'coli-kids' around the huge transporters, watching the crews in their fancy uniforms, speaking in their foreign accents. Mother talked about Earth sometimes, but I always felt Mars was my home and still do. When I turned 18 though, my parents proudly announced that they would be sending their son back to Earth to finish his education, at the University of New Delhi.

Earth was fantastic; New Delhi was warm and teeming with life. I studied political science for four years before joining the Environmental Department of what was then known as the Global Alliance – a cooperation forum for the different governments of Earth to work together in the planets' best interest. These were anxious times on Earth. The Odysseus Probes had been flung out into the farthest reaches of the galaxy almost a century before in search of habitable planets, and still hadn't returned any signal. The eco system on Earth was strained; her natural resources had just about reached breaking point and industrial corporations were collapsing all over the planet, leaving ever-swelling numbers unemployed. Those corporations that managed to hang on were forced to merge in order to survive. My work in the Environmental Department took me through the corridors of power and around the globe, gathering and presenting information for senior political officials. I collaborated with many talented scientists, and in particular one very dedicated man by the name of Dr. Altra King. We had many worried discussions as we watched conflicts arise between the newly formed super corporations, not to mention growing tensions on Earth over the environment and resource depletion.

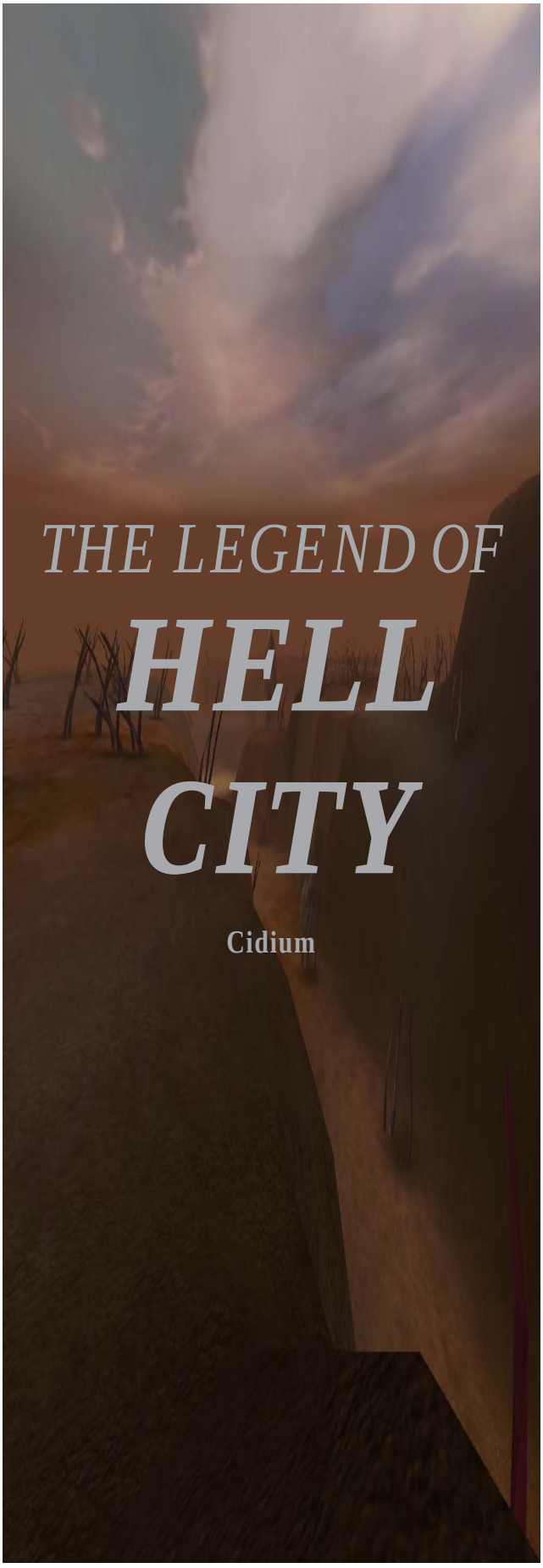
Corporation conflicts began to erupt in remote parts of the universe that were so far away that they were outside the reach of the Global Alliance. I was asked at this point to join a diplomatic corps that was assigned to resolve these conflicts. Fearing that these conflicts would spread to the home world colonies of Mars and the Moon and ultimately Earth itself, the Global Alliance decided to reform itself into a new authority for the planet Earth. The Federal Empire of Earth was born.

In its new mightier form, the Federal Empire employed a large portion of political diplomacy and even a small flexing of its military muscle to squash the corporate squabbling on these distant worlds – the corporate industry lobby was after all, still contributing sizeable sums to the Federal Empire's budget, so they couldn't be dealt with too heavy handedly.

The Federal Empire then assumed a more active role in the governing of these remote planets, a move that didn't sit very well in the corporate world; they interpreted it as the beginning of Federal domination of the resources on these planets. Cutting out the middleman, so to speak. Soon whispers began circulating of a new 'Corporate Alliance' that was being formed, an alliance that could seize power from the Federal Empire.

This is where I came in, and little did I know, that the next few weeks would send my life in a direction no one could have ever imagined. I came home one evening and found a hand written note slipped under my door, "The Supreme Imperial Chancellor needs your help. Please contact me, Lt. Parisa Entenak."

To be continued...in the next issue of *The Gate.*



The tale has been shared throughout generations. Although there is little proof of its existence, common lore has granted the mysterious location with the title Hell City. The environment is said to be extremely vile, and dangerous. Vast fields of radioactive plasma litter the landscape. This area is definitely not suitable for human life, which makes it quite desolate. While known life is rare within Hell City, rich volcanic mineral deposits have formed in abundance. These large crystal formations have been the main point of interest behind such a story. The thought of claiming such magnificent deposits has many settlers thinking of adventure.

The exact location of Hell City is unknown; nonetheless many still seek its fortune. Often, those who wander out in search of its presence return with empty hands. However, there have been a few cases reported, where the individual does not return at all. Dr. Nethanial Huntz, a well-known geologist from N.I.G.I. *[1] had supposedly survived the journey; however, he returned with a variety of malicious tumors throughout the body, and died soon after his arrival. Before his death, Huntz had provided the medical team with his personal paper journal, which was badly damaged. It is quite common for explorers to use paper journals, rather than the more efficient computer data devices. The reason for this is that certain areas of the planet are known to give off unusually intense magnetic fields, making it impossible to use most small, computer operated equipment. Although the majority of the journal entries are illegible due to moisture damage and corrosion, one of the first medical personnel on the scene, Dr. Sven Valgatan claims to have recovered some of the data. Dr. Valgatan has generously provided *The Gate* with his findings. Unfortunately, the entries were not fully recoverable, and are quite broken up. Here is what we have been given:

Date] XXXX0205… route was exactly as I had expected. Due to debris, the engine of the OSI-14*[2] has taken some damage. …components have deteriorated during the journey. I am confident it will take a few days for the amp to charge. … theories were correct, the environment is extremely harsh and I have been required to use the halsuit*[3] immediately upon my arrival. … set up temporary quarters, and begin my studies tomorrow.

Date] XXXX0206...The mineral deposits in this area are obelisk shaped, which is odd. I've noted two colors, deep black and smoke red. … as to the composition of the black deposits, however … seems to contain a variety of toxic, and radioactive content. … be a white precipitate accumulating on the exterior of the deposits. Samples prove this substance to be extremely corrosive. … geological data collected, there is no sign of any form of life. … large storm is imminent; I must retire for the ...

Date] XXXX0207... storm is unlike anything I have

cont...

witnessed on this planet. Humidity is close to 100%, as the vapor appears to collect on all … bolts charge and release in a horizontal direction from one large mineral deposit to another. …The protective skin surrounding my quarters has begun to corrode; I am unsure how long it will last if the ... Furthermore, most of my equipment, and rations have become useless due to the storm. … I fear my suit has also suffered some deterioration, as my epidermis seems quite irritated…

Date] XXXX0208
… I had suspected, my suit is not working properly. … Various sized boils have appeared along my entire body. The corrosive vapor has severely impaired … breathing system, as I am forced to inhale some of the toxicities surrounding me. … the ability to speak has almost completely diminished. … the storm seems to be settling, and I will be able to depart this hell …

Date] XXXX0209
… condition has worsened. Vision seems blurred, as my eyes are constantly burning… areas of the suit have decayed completely. My epidermis has suffered burns, and overall deterioration. Hair loss is apparent, and speech is impossible. … Each breath is difficult to execute, … may not survive the journey home. Please note the location as … order to get there, you must cross… be on the left. Do not seek this location without proper, heavy hazard protection. … I am setting course back to Neo Ithaca. … the auto-cruise is working sufficiently, since I am in no condition to pilot the OSI-14. … deepest apologies to the N.I.G.I., I blatantly disobeyed … not to seek out Hell City. … curiosity is the nature of all human beings. Unfortunately, I notice many of my previous entries have corroded, … the raw data has been lost. I can confirm that it will be worth while to plan excavation, and study of this area…

N.I.G.I. representative, Nolan Brians, denies all knowledge of Hell City, although he confirms that Dr. Huntz did take an OSI-14 personal hovercraft, along with various other pieces of equipment from the facility prior to his departure. Brians has also stated that molecular reconstruction of Dr. Huntz is not a possibility. Dr. Huntz belongs to the N.O.E.L.*[4] society, where all members believe in Earth's old traditional human life cycle. Consequently, the opportunity to acquire the location of Hell City has been lost to nature. Perhaps in time, some brave soul will seek out this legendary city, and prove the story is more than just a myth shared between friends at the local Junkyard Bar.

*[1] N.I.G.I. stands for Neo Ithaca Geological Institute, which is one of the most advanced research facilities on Calypso.
*[2] OSI-14 is the model of personal sized hovercraft used in Dr. Huntz expedition.
*[3] Halsuit is a self-sustaining hazard suit often used in harsh environments.
*[4] N.O.E.L. stands for Nature Over Eternal Life.

Entropia Broadcast Network

Coming Soon



Sayah King

Do you want up-to-the-minute, late-breaking news that chronicles Calypso? Coming soon…**EBN**!

The Gate has struck a deal with the Information Ministry of the Federal Empire that will see the launch of a TV channel in the coming months. It will be called the Entropia Broadcast Network. *The Gate* will assist in the production of online EBN broadcasts while continuing to publish its regular instalment of the magazine. The format will be all news, all the time, but that could change in the future to allow for more feature and current affairs programming. Broadcasts will be recorded on the space station Exodus, orbiting Calypso. The studio is under construction and will soon be ready for EBN's arrival. Well-known broadcast journalist Sayah King has been hired by EBN to host its flagship newscast.

Stay tuned for an EBN launch date to be posted in *The Gate*.



TRAVEL GUIDE

Helen Praetorius

BILLY'S SPACESHIP AFTERWORLD



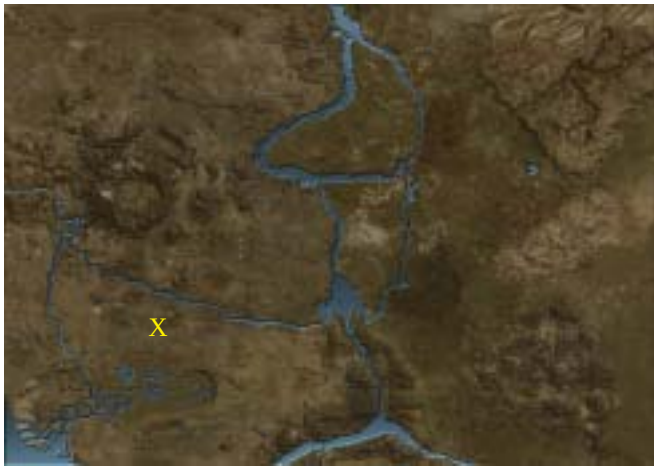
Billy Eastwood

Experience this amazing spot located in the fascinating Erebus region of Calypso. Originally this was a junkyard and storage area for derelict space ships. Today it has turned into a permanent outpost. The highlight of this location is that it provides all citizens with the possibility to hook up with each other and explore. I encourage you to share your Calypso adventures and experiences with fellow settlers.

Billy Eastwood is the supervisor of the outpost. The Federal Empire assigned Billy and several other volunteers to guard the isolated spaceship storage area from mutant scavengers; otherwise they would dismantle all the ships overnight in search for metal scrap and other useful parts. Ever since the new robot invaders appeared, the problems with mutants have decreased. This resulted in the transformation of the area into a fully functional outpost. Due to the fact that Billy is extremely vigilant and loyal to his duty to guard the ships, the outpost was named after him. You may not always see him because he has designated hiding spots to keep watch, but he and his volunteers are there so you can feel safe.

Billy's Spaceship Afterworld provides the perfect opportunity to get a close look at some of the incredible vessels that brought the first citizens to Calypso. Some of these spaceships are still in use today with the intention of transporting settlers to their new home on Calypso. They will also be sent on missions across the planet.





The Ultimate Adventure

If you enjoy nature, I suggest you take a hike up to the north. You will discover that on the other side of a small creek is a beautiful landscape of rocky terrain leading up to the mighty volcano peaks. A bit further south is an enormous and treacherous swamp that is hidden in a thick veil of mist – a voyage you shouldn't miss.

If you want to step even further back in time you don't have too look far; the old battlefields from the previous war against the robots is only a blink away. For the more adventurous and experienced citizen the vast swamps nearby pose an irresistible challenge…

This area is located at X 8127, Y 0633 on the map. Getting there is part of the great adventure, but I can assure you that you won't be disappointed. Stay tuned for more hot travel tips in our next issue. Bon Voyage!

In this first issue of *The Gate*, we would like to take the opportunity of introducing you to the world of PE fashion.

The main purpose of the fashion section is to show the limitless opportunities that exist for Calypso colonists to express their creativity in clothes and accessories. Every month we will provide features such as the most popular clothing items, futuristic accessories, and the best-dressed colonist on Calypso, to mention just a few. This section will also include and highlight the latest clothing designs from our development team. We will feature much more than just clothing; look for accessories like armor, shoes and hairstyles as well. Each facet of fashion will contribute to various trends on Calypso. One day PE will have its own Haute Couture fashion shows with the latest styles strutting down the catwalk!

Ultimately, the question of which look is most appealing for a user is very personal. A large part of the feeling of a look being "right" is linked to how much it allows people to express themselves. It goes to the heart of what feels real and creates an experience that signals, "I'm here". With the increasing amount of outfits that Project Entropia will contain, we will help ensure that all colonists can demonstrate their desired personality within this virtual world. We want everyone to be involved in the creation of Project Entropia fashion.



Any woman can look relaxed and feel confident like this girl wearing a new golden collection of clothes from *Star Satin*. Outfits like these guarantee to keep your style in tune with any fashion on Calypso. The man has an outfit to fit his attitude, dressed in a tight colorful sweater and a pair of pants designed by *Renegade Fashion Products.*



These outstanding clothes are from a collection designed by *Spiral Street* who see their products as a new standard of modern urban street wear. Fifty percent attitude and fifty percent clothes is one of their mottos, and if you wear a full range of their clothes, you're already there.

Calypso Fashion

Helen Praetorius

Helen's Tip of the Month

Never limit yourself - why not dress up for combat and fight in style?

"They say that people wear armor and cool people wear clothes, but personally I like to dress up in both. That way I feel ready for any special occasion."

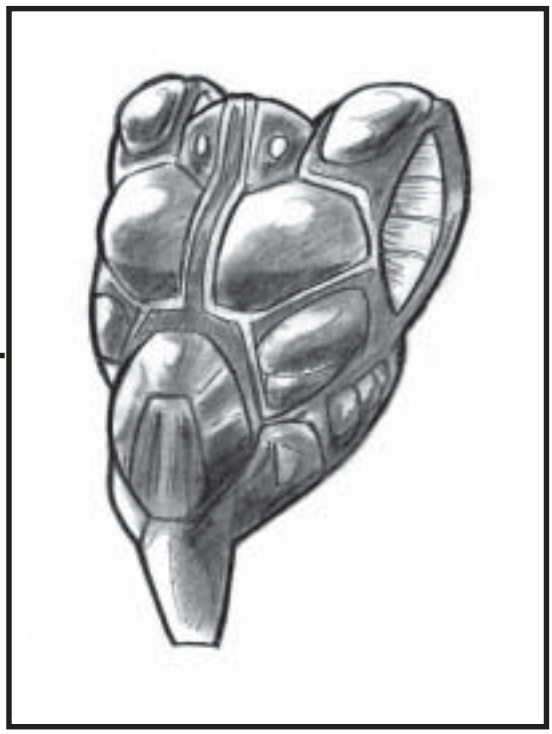
-Ulyssia Starborne, Citizen of Calypso

I'll be back next month with style suggestions and more...

OCTOBER REVIEW

Modified Shadow Armor Harness

Cidium



Description

The eccentric and flamboyant designer Di-Yomeran DeWille once made a very limited series of the exclusive Shadow armor. The Lucky Carcasses Mercenary League asked if DeWillie was willing to produce 100 sets of modified Shadow armor for the Leagues members.

Estimated Statistics

Value	175+
Weight	6.2
Protection Stab	30.0
Protection Cut	60.0
Protection Impact	60.0
Protection Penetration	30.0
Protection Shrapnel	8.0
Protection Burn	60.0
Protection Acid	8.0
Protection Electric	8.0
Durability Cut	6000.0
Durability Impact	6000.0
Durability Penetration	6000.0
Durability Shrapnel	6000.0
Durability Burn	6000.0
Durability Cold	6000.0
Durability Acid	6000.0
Durability Electric	6000.0

Review

One of the most prestigious forms of combat armor, Modified Shadow Armor is extremely rare. Sought after by many, only a handful of fortunate individuals within the universe of Project-Entropia parade themselves in such attire. Acquiring it requires a great deal of personal risk, as only the most brutal and enduring of enemies will grant such a prize. The armor itself is quite dark in color, providing the user with supreme camouflage during night operations. With a terminal value of more than five times that of the Hunter harness, the MSA harness provides astounding protective qualities. A standard Hunter harness will provide 4.5 points of protection against impact, but the MSA harness usually supplies the wearer an incredible 60 points. In addition to the unmatched protective qualities, this piece of combat armor is durable enough to withstand a direct blast from a seismic bomb the size of an Atrax. Unfortunately, the force of the explosion will turn this piece of armor into a blunt, point blank projectile, which will most likely liquify all internal organs. It is safe to say the user will probably die before this item needs repair.

Positive:

The Modified Shadow Armor harness is surprisingly lightweight considering the protection and durability it provides. Protection and durability, need I say more?

Negative:

There are some things in this world that are just… perfect. Oh, and you might want to save your pennies if you decide to buy one off the street.

SOCIETY PROFILE

Stephanie Haines

This part of the Fanzine profiles one of the dozens of societies in existence, waiting to take up operation inside Project Entropia. Introducing The Acadian Society

The year was 1755. The place was Acadia on the east coast of Canada, what we now know as New Brunswick and Nova Scotia. A group of primarily French settlers was forced from their homeland by the English; some across the ocean back to Europe, others to the southern United States to what is now known as Louisiana. But many Acadians fought and escaped the wrath of the English, holding on to their identity. Their heritage lives on in their descendants.

These descendants have formed the Acadian Society, a clan that plans to make its mark on the planet of Calypso.

So says co-founder Jasmin Jean, "...we're Acadians...proud people, and we want to show the world what we are capable of. Trust us with an eye, keeping the other one free to watch your back..."

The Acadian Society's main goal is to achieve absolute perfection and to be one step above all the other nations on Calypso and the Entropia Universe.

"We simply want to stand out from the others. We've noticed that a lot of these societies out there with countless members are made of gamers who just like to play online. But us, we all know each other, we all know how our partners are playing, we can have face-to-face discussions," says Jasmin.

Right now, the society consists of eight members, all fellow Acadian friends who like to play games online. But Jasmin says that number will jump when people get the "spark" for it.

Jasmin first got the "spark" for Project Entropia in December of 2001, after hearing about it from a friend. "The friend" is Keith Lanteigne, the other co-founder of the Acadian Society. He read about PE in an article about online role-playing games. The two guys looked up the website and the rest is history….

The society has two Prime Ministers, to avoid abusive power. There will also be several branches of government from defense and agriculture, to foreign affairs and secret services. Military and defense will be top priority. Equality is another stance the society takes seriously, with plans to be the first nation on Calypso to have a government led by a woman.

If you're interested in joining, log onto the society's website at www.geocities.com/acadiansociety/home. Non-Acadians are welcome, but will not have any political powers. Those interested in government positions will have to undergo a test. "They will be questions that only people living in Acadia know the answers to, and not stuff you can find in books or on the Internet. If you're a true Acadian, the test should be as easy as counting 1-2-3," says Jasmin. Oh yeah...It might also be helpful to speak French.

Go Acadia! So I am a little biased being from Canada, eh?

The society function will soon be operational inside Project Entropia.



FAN PROFILE

Every month we plan to profile a loyal fan of PE, so all of you can get to know the real characters behind the avatars you meet online. This issue we meet Phaelix.



Who is Robert Quackenbush?

I am a 36 year old single father of 4 wonderful children. I work for Ford Motor Co. (Twin Cities Assembly Plant) on the day shift. I am what is refereed to as a Utility in the Body Build Department. I do a wide range of jobs at the plant and actually almost like my job!) My kids are ages 17, 16, 14 and 12. I have 2 boys and 2 girls. I work 10 hours per day 5 days per week and plan on spending about 7 additional hours per day playing PE. I just sold my house in St. Paul (Minnesota) and am presently getting ready to move.

Is there a story behind the name Phaelix you chose for PE?

Yes, there is. Phaelix is a name I started to use about 20 years ago (give or take a couple years) when D&D (Dungeons & Dragons) first came out. It was the name of my first character (a Human Bard) and one that I just can't seem to get rid of.

Are you a veteran MMORPGer? When and why did you start playing?

Yes, I am. I don't even remember when I started to play or the name of the very first game it was that I played. I have played many different games through the years but the one I liked the best was UO (Ultima Online). I think at the time they had the right mix of things to do and interaction amongst the players. I got into playing MMORPG's after being involved in RPG's like D&D and After Math.

How did you first get interested in PE? And what drew you to this virtual universe?

I had been getting board with UO and one day my brother told me about a new game coming out soon called Project Entropia. He said it was supposed to have a lot of the same functionality as UO but set in a futuristic setting and was going to be using a monetary system that a person could remove game money and turn it into real cash! (That got my attention) as well as it's being FREE. As I use to buy and sell game items from UO and EQ on Ebay this sounded like it would be something that I might be able to enjoy and make some money at the same time.

How does PE compare to other MMORPG's that you have played?

PE is in its infancy and as such is hard to sum up, but as I look back on all the other games I've played PE has the makings to surpass all the other games hands down. The graphics are as good as EQ, the playability surpasses UO in its intricacies and technology. Project Entropia is the game I have been waiting for and my wait is finally over.

Tell us about Uni-Corp., PEBC and PESC.

The idea behind UUI (the concept) was my brother's (Gary Quackenbush), simply because he is the one who introduced me to PE and pointed out the various ways in which we could make money. UUI (the realization) was my doing. After I learned about PE, studying the forums and talking with some of the users in the IRC channels, I decided to set up the UUI Society based on the principles of a company (provide products and needed services to the PE community). After looking over my Society for several weeks and talking with some of its members it dawned on me that almost everything we wanted to do within PE could also be offered in the real world (UUI the Corporation is born). UUI the company will be the driving force behind our other assets (PEBC and PESC). The PEBC was originally started to host all the UUI ventures but after a short while I realized that we were going to need a second website to assist us in this huge undertaking. Now, the PEBC will mainly be used as a data source for the PE community and the PESC will be the business end of the UUI company.



cont...

What do you hope to accomplish with these organizations?

Well, basically these organizations are meant to provide a wide range of products and services to the PE community; to become a stable, trustworthy, reliable source of everything citizens of Calypso will need. Instead of dealing with unknown players, people will have a business that they can trust, which is very important in a game where people can make or lose money. UUI hopes to establish a high standard of business practices that others will strive to follow. UUI's goal isn't to rule other businesses, but will be a dominant player in the PE economy. Since real money is a huge part of this game, we feel that economic stability is very important. With our wide range of products and services, and strategic alliances with other businesses, we feel that we are in a very good position to become a dominant player in both the products and services industries on Calypso. While every company's goal is to turn a profit, we feel that it is also very important to reinvest money into Calypso to help in the success of Project Entropia.



Where do you see yourself and PE in 5 years?

In 5 years I feel that Project Entropia will become one of the most popular online communities on the Internet. The fact that players can play for free and make real money will draw a huge number of people to PE. As Project Entropia grows, UUI will grow along with it. In 5 years I see UUI growing to become one of the success stories that MA talks about in their business plan. I would love to see UUI grow to become a household name on Calypso and be able to employ people to play PE on a full time basis.

DID YOU KNOW...

.....that the name Project Entropia stems from the controversial plan devised by the Imperial Senate to defeat the menacing robots. The group plans to let the robots develop and deploy new technology, but upon their defeat, recover and extract that technology in order to increase the research and technological development of the settlers and humankind itself. The technology would then be used to create new weapons against the robots, in the hope that it will lead to their demise. The group feels the superior ability of humans to adapt and invent things through logical and abstract thinking will outweigh the strictly logical robotic mind. However, the downside of this plan is that the robot invasion of Calypso must continue. Citizens of Calypso who must live with the everyday struggle against the robot invaders once called the land 'New Eden' - they now call it Entropia.

Don't forget that you can meet the PR team at Atlas Haven weekdays during office hours (between 6:30 and 3:30 UTC/GMT).

Stop by for a chat!

Ask Bertha 'Bot

Bertha 'Bot is a robot constructed by Dr. Flab Bib shortly before he died. While working on damaged Robot warriors from the Robot War in an attempt to discover ways of disabling them, Bertha 'Bot was a pet project of his – a robot whose banks have been filled with as much human understanding and feelings as possible. Bertha has since become a popular figure on Calypso and was asked to take care of the Advice column for The Gate.



Hi Bertha,
As a newly arrived colonist to Calypso I have been finding it very hard to meet somebody from the opposite sex. I've been hunting and mining and have a fine store of metals and hides that should impress any woman. I'm beginning to get very lonely. Have you any advice for me Bertha?
Lonely

Dear Lonely
Do not despair human. Weaknesses in your neurological systems make humans prone to inefficient thought processes. Loneliness is the result of thinking too much about yourself. I prescribe a visit to one of the society terminals on Calypso where you can join groups of other humans. It is also suggested that you visit Atlas Haven, where it is reported that many humans wishing to find a mate gather.

Dear Bertha,
I've been on Calypso for six months now and haven't managed to move an inch. I have been standing at exactly the same spot, looking at the same thing for what seems like an eternity. I've been attacked by animals, laughed at by other colonists and shot at. I've tried everything with my joystick and just can't seem to get going. I've plugged it into every port, pressed almost every button and nothing happens. Please Bertha can you help me get going?
Frustrated

Dear Frustrated
Press 'W'.

Bertha,
I have no cash and therefore can't buy anything. What am I to do on Calypso – am I destined to be a beggar? Help me Bertha!
Poor

Dear Poor,
You must use your ingenuity and do a lot of work. You must search every square meter of Calypso and see if you can find any discarded items from other colonists. You must search every animal carcass to see if there is any loot left, and every fallen robot. You may bring newly arrived colonists to the best hunting spots in exchange for a PED. You must accumulate knowledge and information about Calypso, which can be sold to others. As a last resort, you must stand outside the main gate of a city and beg for your very life.

Whether you're an established colonist or you've just arrived, and you've got something on your mind, just ask Bertha 'Bot. Write to:
fanzine@project-entropia.com

Project Entropia has talented users with the rhythm and rhyme for poetry. A user named Merrmaid began a thread one day calling for all those with a poet inside them to post their works on the website's general forum board. The response was overwhelming. Here is some of the work from our Creative Calypsians.



Calypso, new earth mother,
lustrous gem,
though I spring not from your loins,
I fight and scratch
to make my way within
and bring forth some small sacrament,
the precious essence of your womb.

Forgive me, good matriarch,
but your untamed frontiers
tug at my purse,
ever empty,
and tease the limits of my sustenance
until my choice is nil
but to seek my livelihood in your substance.

Yet, I will praise thee in song,
my sacred and holy host,
when long cluttered your horizons are.
I will speak in psalms
of your golden plains,
carol of your heaven-reaching peaks,
chant the rhythms
of your sweet, crystal waters
that once were.

I will tell my children of your beauty,
faded, not forgotten,
and as they reach deeply for the dregs of your nectar,
they will know you as once I did,
if only with eyes closed.
Written by Merriman

Calypso – A Haiku

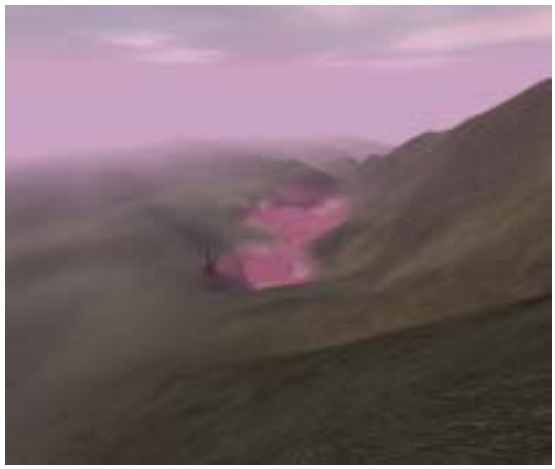
frightened mountain breaks
martyr gropes, mangy brides screech
weakly, pond drips, lush
Written by Jae



Calypso Rhapsody
Listen to the winds of Calypso. Exotic notes whisper as the wind drifts through my hair, blissful drops of moisture feather my eyelids as I look into the cool turquoise waters. Ahhh, Calypso, your passion engulfs me, I catch my breath as I stare into your murky depths, hauntingly beautiful, a mystery-laden land of enchantment. You are my past, my present, my future to be experienced. Let me bathe in all the wonders you have within you, let me breathe in your out worldly essence and learn to love you. Let me become a part of you...Calypso.
Written by Merrmaid

Brought fourth to translate,
from celestial song to Calypsian speak,
making his presence known to millions,
digitally,
virtually,
lovingly,
powerfully.

We wait in wonder as the universe is created before our eyes
having a hand in our own creation,
having a hand in the formation of the world,
we wait in wonder as the bug colonies are excavated with each new patch
having now a chance to explore the unknown without caution or fear
we wait in wonder as the reset unfolds us into a life reborn
this is the new beginning, but is it the last?
we wait in wonder at the glory of His Purpose
Written by Schwanke



Send us your creative writing to fanzine@project-entropia.com

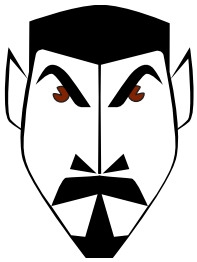


CONTRIBUTORS

A great deal of time and effort went into the inaugural issue of *The Gate*. Now is the time to thank all those who put their creative minds, hearts and souls into it. Here are the contributors:

Cidium
Writer

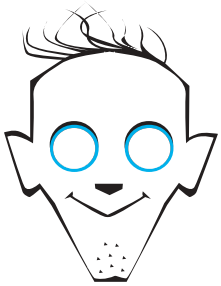
Peter Alfredsson
Portraits



Frank Campbell
Writer
Design



Helen Praetorius
Writer
Design
Photo Research



Fredrik Andersson
Illustrations

What to watch for in the next issue of *The Gate:*

The Editorial: An Outsider Looking In
by Stephanie Haines

Part II of The Diary of Ero Hartstenner
by Frank Campbell

A review of the PE weapon, A&P Series Freedom
by Cidium

The latest clothing and accessories in PE
by Helen Praetorius

More graphics, more content, more fun, more PE!

Final Word

Well, I guess the final word should be uplifting and positive, something that expresses our appreciation of the fans, that says thank you to our community and testers. It should taste like pride, while at the same time expressing humility. It should mean something for the staff at MindArk, who have done a brilliant job in bringing this project so far. It should feel like turning a page to a new chapter. OK, lets see what happens… PHEW.
(Is that a word? Well it is now.)